



T-34/85

The T-34 was described as the “best tank in the world” by the German General Paul Ludwig Ewald von Kleist when his forces first encountered it in the summer of 1941. Its success was based partly on its design, and partly on its use in huge numbers, and it was able to defeat more technically advanced opposition vehicles.

THE T-34 WAS a powerfully armed and well-protected medium tank designed by Mikhail Koshkin at the end of the 1930s (see pp.102–103) to replace the earlier BT series of fast tanks. Its groundbreaking design was influenced by lessons learned fighting the Japanese at Khalkhin Gol in 1939. It had thicker armor and a larger gun than its predecessors, and a diesel engine that was considered less of a fire risk than earlier gasoline engines, which had been vulnerable to incendiary devices.

During trials of the new tank in the spring of 1940, Koshkin caught pneumonia, of which he was to die in September—the same month that the first production tanks rolled out of the factory. Improvements to the design continued throughout the war, many of which intended to reduce production costs and times: the cost of a T-34 dropped from 269,500 to 135,000 rubles. This need for simplicity was partly driven by production facilities moving to new sites behind the Ural Mountains due to the advancing German armies. The T-34 went on to be made in Poland and Czechoslovakia, and tens of thousands of them saw service in armies worldwide. This version, the T-34/85, has an enlarged turret to house the commander, gunner, and loader, and is named after its upgraded 85 mm gun.



REAR VIEW



SPECIFICATIONS	
Name	T-34/85
Date	1940
Origin	Soviet Union
Production	84,700
Engine	Model V-2-34 V12 diesel, 500 hp
Weight	35.3 tons (32 tonnes)
Main armament	85 mm ZIS S-53
Secondary armament	2 x 7.62 mm DT machine guns
Crew	5
Armor thickness	Max 2.4 in (60 mm)

Gunner

Loader

Engine

Commander

Driver